

Title: What I learned from analyzing over 100 Master rank solo queue replays

Score:

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First things first, I have to disillusion you about what Master rank gameplay looks like. All of the following moments are from solo queue Master rank games patch 25.19 to 25.24. I'm not here to "name and shame", so I won't reveal any usernames.

- The team of a super fed Akali fights 4v5 without her at Baron and loses. Akali recalls, runs to the Baron pit, jumps into it over the wall and instantly dies. Her team then loses another 4v5 and the game is over.

- Only 6 minutes in and blue team's Varus adc already died three times to Taric and Swain botlane. His support moved midlane. Varus respawns, walks back to lane and waits in the bush next to Krugs, while Swain and Taric move up the lane to proxy farm. Once they're right next to him, Varus shoots his E at them, revealing his position. Swain retaliates. Varus gets stunned and dies again.

- Blue team's Caitlyn adc and Morgana support are the only two survivors of a lategame teamfight. They run up midlane and destroy red team's inhib and nexus turrets. Then Caitlyn walks into the enemy spawn fountain. Morgana doesn't deal enough damage to destroy the nexus. Red team respawns, kills Morgana and wins the game.

- Graves jungle chases after the enemy Kai'Sa adc. She runs behind her tower to safety. Graves flashes under the tower and shoots R. Kai'Sa survives with 20% HP left, while Graves gets shot twice by the tower and dies.

- Red team invades blue team's jungle, while the blue team defends their mid tower. Blue team's

Fizz sneaks into the jungle as well and engages 1v3 using R-Q on the enemy Lulu support. Lulu flashes away over a wall. Fizz does E-Flash to pursue her, but fails to flash against the wall and dies.

- Poppy jungle tower dives the enemy adc, gets an assist and walks away with only 250 HP left. From there she moves straight into Fiddlestick's jungle, sees the full HP Fiddlesticks standing around at the cross section. She stops for a moment, then walks up to him, gets feared and dies.

- Red team does a 5 man level 1 invade on blue team's botlane jungle. Blue team's support walks by and everyone gives chase, except for red team's adc, who breaks away to fight the enemy adc 1v1. Support and adc both escape. Red team's adc used flash and got nothing for it. The laners leave, but their Talon jungle insists on fighting blue team's level 2 Diana anyway and dies. Same game, 5 minutes later, Talon just killed Diana's midlaner. His own Leblanc is still in lane. Diana follows Talon into his jungle. She has neither boots nor wards. She walks all the way to Talon's wolf camp, finds it empty and walks to dragon to fight it 1v1 at level 4. In the meantime Talon killed Gromp, then also clears wolves just as they spawn, walks to botlane, finds Diana still fighting the dragon and gets a free kill + dragon. (Diana's team still won)

- Red team takes Baron and wins 2 teamfights in a row, scoring an Ace while in blue team's base. Quinn and Dr. Mundo are the only survivors. They destroy the Nexus turrets. Then Mundo walks into the enemy spawn fountain for some laser hair removal. Quinn doesn't deal enough damage to destroy the Nexus by herself. Blue team respawns and kills both Mundo and Quinn. Red team's AP Twitch tries to backdoor, but gets caught and dies. Blue team wins the game.

- A lategame 5v5 teamfight breaks out midlane. Blue team's melees engage on red team's Xin Zhao. He ults. Blue team's Kayle, Ashe and Seraphine all focus fire on Xin Zhao for the entire duration of his ult, even though they all stand outside of the circle, so he takes 0 damage. In the meantime Xin's

backline kills their frontline and wins the fight.

- Ezreal dies for the second time at 06:00. His Karma support gets so mad that she walks into a toplane bush and plays living ward for the rest of the game. (Ezreal's team still got a gold lead during the mid-game, but the number advantage became too much eventually.)

- Kennen top is 5-1-1 by 17:00. The enemy team besieges mid turret. Kennen engages with ult. It would've been 4v4, but his team doesn't follow up and he dies. Kennen Alt+F4s. His team loses the game.

- Red team's Lee Sin tower dives the enemy Samira on midlane, gets the kill, barely survives and walks away into the jungle. But then he stops, throws his Q at a passing blue midlane minion and jumps onto it. There aren't any red minions left under the tower, so Lee Sin gets turret aggro and dies. Samira gets the shut down bounty ends up super fed 5 minutes later.

- Vi and Yasuo tower dive Jax, but don't manage to finish him off. Yasuo tanked the tower and leaves to proxy farm, while Vi goes back in for the kill. However she hit Jax with red buff earlier, so she immediately gets turret aggro. She reacts too late, gets shot twice and dies, leaving Yasuo stuck on the wrong side of the tower.

I could go on, but I think this is enough.

Evidently, Master ranks are no genius strategists and still have plenty of "noob habits" in addition to being ragequitters and trolls. They also try to surrender whenever anything goes wrong. It's not rare to see both Master teams hold surrender votes at the same time.

In short: you can never drop the 1v9 mentality, not even in Master rank. It is the same thing as in every other elo, except you play against maximum difficulty opponents.

Also, these are all great examples for why you shouldn't surrender. Never overestimate your opponents. They may be Master rank and currently have a 7k gold lead, but there is a good chance they'll just hand you the win on a silver platter a few minutes later.

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Now the big question; if it isn't for smarts or wisdom, how did Master ranks manage to climb so high? I can only theorize that it is a mixture of the following:

- Overall speed. Fast combo execution. Fast decision making. They would rather make a wrong decision than be idle. Fast reactions, like when someone dodged a Gragas E with a sideways Flash, the Gragas player was able to Flash after them in the right direction so that the E still hit.

- Mechanics. Primarily fighting and Flash usage. Between Master ranks, who wins the 1v1 often comes down to Flash. Knowing if your opponent has Flash is about as important as knowing if they have ult. When I catch a Master rank in Normal Draft and all the other players are only Gold to Emerald, the Master rank turns into a one-man-army and kills the entire enemy team one after another on repeat in a series of consecutive 1v1s. It's really hard to shut them down without Flash-CC because they're so good at dodging, spacing, etc.

- Multitasking and map awareness. They probably don't *actually* have eyes everywhere, but it feels that way. They instantly notice the enemy jungle icon on the minimap and warning ping on it. Botlane knows if the enemy toplane is low HP and vice versa. (They also use this to be toxic and

backseat teammates. Like when I spectated a Shen midlaner and he died 1v1 to Orianna even though he could have flashed her ult, the Rakan support on botlane saw it happen and proceeded to spam the "Shen Flash - Ready" ping in chat for the next 2 minutes.)

- Farming. Master ranks cs very well. Typically around 80cs by 10:30. Even in melee vs ranged counter matchups or when they're down 0-3-1, they can still get a cs lead. Accordingly, Master ranks also try very hard to deny each other farm. Junglers keep killing camps even when they're super fed and have full build, just to deny it as a source of gold to the enemy.

- Confidence. They make high risk plays without hesitation. They expect their opponents to be dumb and that they can get away with everything - and often times they do.

Of course, not every point applies to every Master rank. The Fizz player who fail flashed had a weakness in the mechanics department. The Diana player lacked confidence. Talon had too much of it. The Lee Sin tower diver was blind to the wave state. The Vi tower diver wasn't aware of her buffs and had slow reaction times to turret aggro. However they can get most of these things done alright.

I also see this reflected when comparing lower ranks. Iron rank solo queue is like watching 500ms ping gameplay. Flash is useless when you stand still for half a second after flashing. Either work on your input speed or play to your limitations and use Ghost instead. I also see Iron II jungle clear times of 04:00 followed by standing still for 10 seconds, presumably to look at every lane and debate about what to do next. By the time the Iron II jungler gets moving, the enemy Bronze III jungler has killed the scuttle crab and recalled to buy a pickaxe, which lets him win the fight in the river a minute later because the Iron jungler still hasn't found the time to spend his gold.

The principle is simple: it is always about winning fights. If you play faster, you'll have higher stats, win more fights and win more games. Doesn't matter if your decisions are suboptimal as long as they contribute to your champion getting stronger. Once stat checking alone isn't enough anymore, you need to work on combat skill. Flash, skillshots, spacing.

Now lastly some general observations:

- I found 7 Master rank pentakills: one from a Fiddlesticks support, one from an Ahri top, one Katarina mid, one Hwei mid, one Shyvana jungle, one Akshan mid and lastly one by a Zeri midlaner.
- I only saw a single backdoor victory, which was done by a toplane Gwen with TP. Pentakills seem to be more common than backdoor victories in Master.
- This game moves way faster than it looks. It is impossible to predict what happens 30 seconds into the future. Try it yourself, open a Master rank replay and take notes with time stamps. At 06:40 Morgana is alone on midlane. Her lane opponent recalled after she ulted and he flashed away. Everything is calm, nobody is moving towards midlane. 07:10 There are 3 people on midlane and Morgana is dead in a bush with Gangplank ult raining down on her.
- Putting your CC abilities on cooldown is super risky, even if your lane is currently empty. Example: Master rank Briar mid comes back to lane and Lux just used QE to waveclear before trying to walk back to her tower to recall. Briar runs straight at her, goes W Flash Q-stun Ignite and murders her before Lux's Q comes off cooldown.
- The competition in Master is brutal. Sometimes I see a Master rank player obliterate the enemy team, but then I check that sane player's profile again the next day and find them demoted to

Diamond after they lost 3 games in a row. It must be frustrating to no end considering the silly ways in which Master ranks lose games.

- When moving through the jungle they travel using attack move. It gets you situations like this: a low HP Leblanc searches for Caitlyn after she took dragon. Caitlyn is also low HP and walks to the same corner near blue buff. They enter vision at the same time. Leblanc has fast reactions and jump at Caitlyn with W, but Caitlyn automatically attacks Leblanc and kills her with a single shot mid-jump.

- Master ranks fight a lot, but also die less in total. More than 12 total deaths by 10 minutes is rare.

Not every fight is a fight to the death.

- Supports rarely stay botlane. Sometimes they travel all the way to toplane to help with a tower dive. Roaming supports commonly fall far behind in level, they're often at level 3 when top and mid are level 6.

- There aren't many dedicated "off-meta pick" OTPs in Master, but off-meta picks in general are common. The only really consistent part is that they keep an AD/AP mix and always have someone start with World Atlas botlane. Beyond that anything goes. I've seen Kalista mid, Yorick mid, Gangplank mid, Veigar top, Yunara top, Zed+Zoe vs Kaisa+Janna botlane, Olaf+Nami vs Yasuo+Neeko botlane, Katarina+Pantheon vs Mel+Nautilus botlane, etc.

- I rarely see OTPs get counterpicked when I check their match history. I wanted to see how people who are good with my champions beat the counters I often face, but I couldn't find much footage of it. Instead, most of their games are easy matchups. Shame we can't see champ select in replays.

- I got mixed feelings on Teleport in solo queue now. Not just because Master ranks use it poorly

sometimes (example: Lux TPs to river ward for dragon, but her team runs away and leaves her to die 1v4), but also because it increases the odds of your teammates picking bad fights. I see this live in action when I spectate Challenger rank streamers on Twitch. Ex: the streamer plays adc and initiates a 3v4 at Rift Herald because his toplaner has TP. However the toplaner TPs elsewhere. The streamer and his support die. The enemy team takes Rift Herald. The streamer gets omega tilted and files a report on the toplaner.

Now in retrospect, did watching all those replays make me a better player?

I would say yes, I learned a lot about what my champions are good at and which situations I should avoid, even generalized "rules of thumb" that I can apply in most matchups. I highly recommend checking out Master rank gameplay if you feel insecure about your play. Not necessarily because it will show you how to always win, but so you see them fail too and learn from their mistakes.